For absolute decadence, omit the poached eggs and top each bowl with a little chopped hard-boiled egg and a shucked oyster in its half shell.

wakame soup with poached eggs

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

7oz (200g) fresh or dried wakame
2–3 tbsp unsalted butter
1 large leek, washed thoroughly and sliced
1 large potato, diced
1 thick slice of lemon
small handful of fresh parsley
1 quart (1 liter) light vegetable or chicken stock
pepper
2–3 tbsp milk (optional)
1 tbsp white wine vinegar
4 eggs

1 Rinse the wakame (or soak, if dried), then boil in a little water over medium-high heat for 3–5 minutes or until tender. Drain, rinse with cold water, and drain again.

2 Melt the butter in a large saucepan. Add the leek and potato and cook gently, stirring, for 2 minutes or until soft but not browned. Add the lemon, parsley, stock, and pepper—it's unlikely to need salt as wakame is salty. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat, cover, and simmer gently for 20 minutes, or until the vegetables are really soft. Discard the lemon and process in a blender with the wakame. Return to the pan, taste, and add more pepper if necessary. If freezing, cool and freeze at this point, then defrost and continue. Thin with the milk, if desired, then reheat gently.

3 Meanwhile, bring a large pan of water to a boil and add the vinegar. Swirl around to make an eddy and break in the eggs one at a time. Poach until cooked to your liking, then remove with a slotted spoon. Ladle into wide, shallow soup plates then rest a poached egg in the center of each.